

Population

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The factors that affect population growth

Birth rate :- The birth rate is the ratio of total live births to total population in a country in a given time period. If the birth rate of a country goes up, it will lead to population growth.

The general fertility rate is the number of live birth per 1000 women between the ages of 15 and 44 years. It can also be measured by the number of children born to the average women in her lifetime.

Death rate :- The death or mortality rate is the number of deaths per thousand of the population each year. If the death rate of a country goes down, it will lead to population growth.

The infant mortality rate is the number of children less than one year old dying divided by the number of live births in a particular year.

The maternal mortality rate is the number of deaths of women related to child bearing divided by the total number of live births in a particular year.

Net-migration :- It refers to the difference between immigration, the number

of people moving into a country in a given time period, and emigration, the number of people moving out of a country in a given time period.

If the number of immigrants is greater than the number of emigrants, the net migration figure will be positive and there will be growth in population.

The reasons for different rates of population growth in different countries

1) Differences in birth rates (Birth rates are usually higher in developing countries than in developed countries)

- * People aim to have more children to counteract high levels of infant mortality
- * Children can add to household earning once they start work
- * Knowledge about methods of birth control is generally less widespread in developing countries.
- * The level of female employment can vary between countries and this can affect decisions about whether to have children or not.

- * If there is a tendency to marry later, this could have an effect on birth rate
- * In some countries, people may prefer to have higher standard of living and donot want the expense of having children.

Differences in death rates (Death rates are usually higher in developing countries than in developed countries)

- * The quality of and access to health care varies - there is usually better medical care in developed countries than in developing countries. Medical advances have brought down the death rate in most countries
- * Some countries inoculate more against certain diseases
- * A better diet can cause a fall in death rates. Countries vary greatly in knowledge about the importance of diet and nutrition. Also, the quality of food and water can vary enormously between countries
- * Incomes tend to be lower in developing countries making it more difficult to pay for medical care. The drugs to combat and treat malaria and HIV/AIDS are very expensive.

* Developing countries tend to have fewer doctors, nurses and hospital beds per head of the population than developed countries.

Differences in net migration

* Net migration will be influenced by the relative ease with which people can move between countries.

* People may move from one country to another as a result of war or civil disturbance

* The extent of civil liberties and political freedom in a country may influence migration from one country to another.

* People may move from one country to other if they think that one economy is stronger than another and therefore they have a better chance of gaining employment and earning an income

Optimum population

The concept of an optimum population refers to the ideal population of a country in relation to the availability of resources - the best ratio of people to the resources in an economy. If a country is considered to have a population that is too large in relation to its other resources, it is said to be overpopulated. If the population is too small in relation to its other resources, it is said to be underpopulated.

Benefits of an increase in population size

- * A country will be able to make more effective use of its economic resources as long as it is underpopulated.
- * There will be an increase in the number of potential workers. If the rise in labor force is caused by net immigration of skilled and qualified workers, this will lead to an increase in both quantity and quality of workers.
- * There will be more potential consumers so there will be an increase in the size of markets. Firms will be able to benefit from this, both in terms of increased revenue and reduced costs.

* Extra demand for goods and services could lead to an increase in investment, improving the technological efficiency of production

Disadvantages of an increase in population size

* If the increase in population is greater than the increase in output, there will be a fall in living standards because there will be reduction in GDP per head.

* If a country becomes overpopulated, there may not be enough output to satisfy the people, e.g. there could be a famine.

* Increases in population size could lead to overcrowding, putting pressure on education and housing.

* There could be significant negative environmental effects, such as in relation to pollution and the depletion of non-renewable resources

* The increase in population could lead to a rise in unemployment.

Benefits to a decrease in population size

- * If a country is above its optimum size and a decrease in population brings it to its optimum size, its resources will be more efficiently utilised.
- * If there is a high unemployment, a decrease in population size could lead to a reduction in the rate of unemployment.
- * If there is a high level of inflation, a decrease in population size could reduce the extent of inflationary pressure, especially in relation to demand pull inflation.
- * There may be reduction in the effects of overcrowding and environmental issues

Disadvantages to a decrease in population size

- * There may not be enough people of working age, leading to a reduction in total supply in an economy.
- * If a country cannot supply all of the products wanted by its population, they may need to be imported and this could create difficulties in the current account of the balance of payments.

* There will also be a decrease in the level of total demand in an economy and this could make firms reluctant to invest.

Changes in the age distribution of population

In the majority of countries in the world, the average age of people is increasing. This is known as an ageing population. Average life expectancy has increased; many countries now have a life expectancy at birth in the 70s or 80s. In some countries, over 20% of the population is over 60 years old.

There are both advantages and disadvantages of an ageing population. Older people can be an economic asset because of their greater experience and willingness to take on responsibility, and they can act as advisors and mentors to younger people who will benefit from the advice and guidance given.

However, there will be an increase in the dependency ratio, that is, there will be more workers needed to support each retired person, there will be increased spending by the government for pensions and health care, and this is likely to lead to higher taxes for those in work, with the danger that higher taxes could be a disincentive for workers.

Dependency ratio, the number of people in a country who are unable to work divided by the number of people who are able to work.

Changes in the gender distribution of population

In most countries, more boys than girls are born, but the infant mortality rate is higher for boys than girls. As a result, in most countries there are more girls than boys. This is significant, but its economic effect is being reduced in many countries as female participation in the labour force is being encouraged. For example, some countries are providing nurseries and childcare facilities at subsidised rates to encourage mothers to go out to work.

The gender distribution in a country can be changed by government policy. For example, the one-child policy that was adopted by China for a number of years changed the male/female births ratio from 108/100 to 120/100.

However, there is still inequality between the wages of males and females, despite legislation being introduced in many countries in an attempt to end such inequality. It has been estimated that women make up 60% of the world's working poor.

Population Pyramids

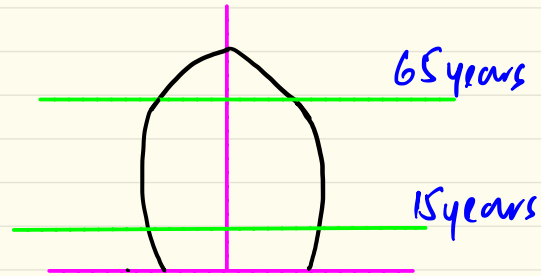
A population pyramid can be used to show the differences between certain features of population in various countries. For example, a population pyramid can show the differences in average life expectancy in developing and developed countries



Pyramid A

Typical of developed countries:

high death rate
high birth rate
low life expectancy



Pyramid B

Typical of developed countries:

Low death rate
Low birth rate
longer life expectancy

Questions

Q1 Define birth rate ? 2

Q2 Define death rate ? 2

Q3 Define general fertility rate ? 2

Q4 Define infant mortality rate ? 2

Q5 Define maternal mortality rate ? 2

Q6 Define immigration ? 2

Q7 Define emigration ? 2

Q8 Explain the reasons for different rates of population growth in different countries ? 18

(
Differences in birth rate, death rate and net migration
(3 points each)

Q9 Explain optimum population ? 4

Q10 Explain the benefits of increase in population size ? 6

Q11 Explain the disadvantages of increase in population size ? 6

Q12 Explain the benefits of decrease in population size ? 6

Q13 Explain the disadvantages of decrease in population size ? 6

Q14 Explain the changes in age distribution of population ? 8

Q15 Explain the changes in gender distribution of population ? 8

Q16 Using diagrams, explain population pyramids ? 8